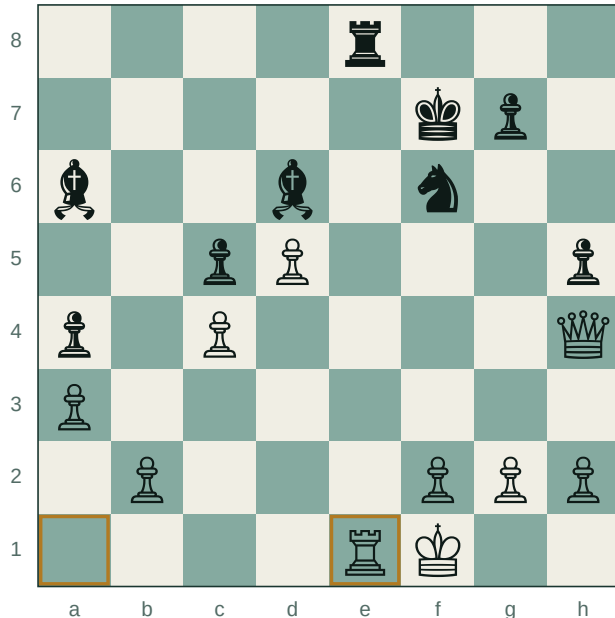


Capture the defender: Black, move 23

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 23.Re1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

23...g5 24. Rxe8 gxh4 25. Ra8 Bxc4+

23...g5 The pawn moves from g7 to g5. Recorded reply: **24.Rxe8**.

24...gxh4 The pawn captures the queen on h4. Recorded reply: **25.Ra8**.

25...Bxc4+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on c4.

At the end, nominal material is White 11 / Black 13 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +5: the balance goes from -3 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on f1. Absolute pin: pawn on c4.